

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Retail Associate and Cashier English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Retail sales associates, cashiers, fitting-room attendants, and shop-floor customer service staff.

All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

accessible checkout

A checkout designed or arranged to support access needs, such as suitable space or counter height.

assistance call

A request to a colleague for help with a customer or store task.

barcode

A machine-readable pattern used to identify an item when scanned.

care label

The attached label stating the manufacturer's garment-care information.

cash discrepancy

A difference between counted cash and the amount expected from the store's records.

checkout lane

A designated route and counter where shoppers complete purchases.

collection notification

A message telling a customer that an order is ready to collect under the stated arrangements; commonly called a pickup notification in US English.

exchange

Replacing a purchased item with another under the applicable store terms.

fit

How a garment's shape and size sit on the wearer.

fitting room

A designated shop space where customers can try on clothing.

lining

An inner layer of fabric inside a garment or bag.

multibuy offer

A promotion requiring the purchase of a stated number of qualifying items.

point-of-sale system

The store equipment and software used to record purchases and process checkout, often abbreviated POS.

price check

A request to verify an item's applicable price when information is unclear.

proof of purchase

A receipt or other evidence the store accepts to establish where and when an item was bought.

queue

A line of shoppers waiting for service; also called a line in US English.

receipt

A record of a completed transaction showing relevant purchase and payment details.

refund

Money returned for a purchase under the applicable decision and payment arrangements.

reserved item

An item held for a specified customer or purpose under stated conditions.

sales floor

The part of a store where goods are displayed and customers shop.

seam

The join where pieces of fabric are stitched together.

shelf-edge label

A label beside displayed goods stating the item description and price.

shift log

A store record of relevant events and open tasks passed between work shifts.

size range

The set of sizes in which a product is offered.

stock-keeping unit

An identifier for a particular product variation, often abbreviated SKU, such as a specific shirt size and color.

stockroom

A store's storage area away from the main customer shopping space.

store credit

Value issued for use at the store rather than money returned to the original payment method.

subtotal

The total for entered items before any separately applied tax, fee, or discount adjustments.

tender

A method or form of payment offered for a purchase, such as cash or a card.

till float

The cash drawer starting balance provided for giving change, separate from the day's sales; often called the starting cash balance in US English.

unit price

A price expressed per standard amount, such as per liter, for comparison.

void

A cancelled transaction or item entry recorded by the point-of-sale system.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask one question that narrows the search

Do you mean the ___ or the ___?

The item code is ___; is that the one?

I'll check this store's stock in ___.

Color alone may describe several items. Use material, code, and size to distinguish them without claiming availability prematurely.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the item code: compare the exact product identifier

find the right size: locate the variation the shopper requests

point out the fitting room: show where clothing can be tried on

narrow down the choice: reduce options by clarifying the shopper's needs

Compare the same practical requirement

Both cost ___, but the labels say ___.

This matches your requirement for ___.

The label doesn't establish ___.

Price, lining, fit, and care are different features. Identify the deciding requirement and avoid extending the label's meaning beyond what it states.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the care label: read the supplied care information

compare the fit: discuss how two garments sit on the wearer

allow room through the shoulders: describe the space available in the upper garment

check the seam position: identify where a stitched join sits

Explain the condition that changes the price

The offer applies when you buy ____.

One item remains ____ under these terms.

That is the average, not ____.

Use the offer's quantity condition and the same price basis. Don't infer a universal pricing rule from this fictional promotion.

Word combinations in this lesson

match the label to the item: compare product description and code

read the offer conditions: identify qualifying quantity and items

compare the unit prices: use the same standard quantity for both products

request a price check: ask a colleague to verify a disputed price

Correct the basket before taking payment

The basket shows ____, but you have ____.

Payment hasn't started, so this is ____.

The revised quantity is ____ and the total is ____.

Name the exact duplicate instead of saying the register is wrong generally. Keep a basket correction separate from a refund after payment.

Word combinations in this lesson

review the basket: check items and quantities before payment

remove a duplicate scan: correct an item entered twice

confirm the amount due: state the total still requiring payment

check transaction status: establish whether payment has completed

Separate policy eligibility from available stock

Under this store's terms, ____ qualifies for ____.

The remaining question is whether ____ is available.

A refund and store credit are different because ____.

A qualifying return does not create stock. Check the purchase conditions and then the requested replacement separately.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the return terms: read the conditions applying to the purchase

bring proof of purchase: provide the accepted purchase record

exchange for another size: replace the item with a different size

refer an exception request: ask the responsible person to review a request outside stated terms

Tell the shopper what the message actually confirms

This confirms ___, not ___.

One item is still ___.

Three o'clock is an update time, not ___.

Use the message's wording and current physical status. An update time is not automatically a collection time.

Word combinations in this lesson

check physical stock: confirm an item is actually present

locate the reserved item: find the goods assigned to the customer

wait for collection confirmation: avoid assuming an order acknowledgment means readiness

check the order reference: use the order identifier to distinguish similar requests

Ask what help is wanted

Would you prefer ___ or ___?

Lane ___ has ___.

May I help with ___?

Address the shopper directly and offer the available route. Ask before handling personal belongings or mobility equipment.

Word combinations in this lesson

open another checkout: make another staffed payment point available

keep the aisle clear: preserve space for people to pass

offer assistance without assuming: ask what help the shopper wants

direct the next customer: guide the next person from the agreed queue order

Hand over the observation, not an accusation

The count is ___ against an expected ___.

The cause remains ___.

Can you take the follow-up on ___?

A discrepancy is a mismatch, not an established cause. Distinguish a cash check from a separate customer's price query.

Word combinations in this lesson

count against the record: compare counted amounts with expected figures

report a discrepancy: state the difference without inventing its cause

keep the transaction reference: preserve the identifier needed for a check

accept the follow-up: explicitly agree to handle an unfinished task

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Finding the item the shopper actually means

A shopper asks for the blue shirt in an advertisement. The ad shows two blue shirts: linen L214 and cotton C218. The shopper wants a medium cotton shirt; local availability has not been checked. Confirm item and size before discussing stock.

The advertisement shows two blue shirts, so let me check which one you mean. Is it the cotton shirt, code C218, in medium? Once we've confirmed that variation, I can check this store's stock. The picture alone doesn't tell us whether your size is available here today.

Try it again: The shopper points at the wrong picture while repeating the cotton code. Clarify before searching.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Comparing fit, materials, and label information

A shopper needs a machine-washable jacket. Jacket A is unlined and its label permits machine washing; B is lined and its label states dry-clean only. Both cost \$60. Compare the stated care requirements without inventing comfort or durability claims.

Both jackets are sixty dollars, but their care labels differ. Jacket A is unlined and labelled for machine washing; jacket B is lined and labelled dry-clean only. Since machine washing is your priority, A matches that stated requirement. You can still compare the fit before deciding.

Try it again: The shopper assumes identical prices mean identical care requirements. Return to the two labels.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

A shopper has one juice bottle priced at \$3. The shelf offer says two qualifying bottles for \$5; single bottles remain \$3. The shopper expects one bottle for \$2.50. Explain the quantity condition without treating half the bundle price as the single-item offer.

The five-dollar offer applies when you buy two qualifying bottles. One bottle is still three dollars under these displayed terms. Two would average two dollars fifty each, but that average isn't the single-bottle price. Would you like one at three, or two qualifying bottles for five?

Try it again: The second bottle is a nonqualifying flavor. Explain that quantity and qualifying item both matter.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Checking the basket and payment status

Two \$8 mugs were scanned, but the shopper has only one. There are no additional charges in this exercise. Payment has not begun. Acknowledge the duplicate, correct the recorded quantity through the store's checkout process, and confirm \$8 before payment.

You're right: the basket shows two mugs, but you have one. I'm sorry about the duplicate scan. I'll correct the quantity before you pay. Your total is now eight dollars, with no additional charges. Please check that the screen shows one mug before we continue.

Try it again: The shopper sees a payment notification from an earlier purchase. Keep it separate from this unpaid basket.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

In this fictional store, an unused shirt with tags and a receipt can be exchanged within thirty days. The shopper bought it ten days ago and wants a larger size. A receipt is present; larger-size stock remains unchecked. Explain eligibility and the stock uncertainty without stating universal return rights.

Your receipt shows the shirt was bought ten days ago. Under this store's stated terms, the unused shirt with its tags qualifies for an exchange within thirty days. We still need to check whether the larger size is here. I'll check that before we agree on the replacement.

Try it again: The larger size is unavailable. Ask about other stated options rather than invent an exception.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Explaining local stock and collection status

A shopper's message acknowledges order R61 but is not a collection notification. One item is still being located. The collection colleague will update the shopper at 3:00, even if unresolved. Do not promise readiness or substitute another variation.

That message confirms receipt of order R61; it isn't a collection notification. One item is still being located, so I can't say the order is ready. The collection colleague will update you at three, including if the search is unresolved. We won't substitute a different variation without asking you.

Try it again: The shopper asks whether choosing another color automatically makes the order ready. Keep substitution and readiness separate.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Managing queues and offering practical assistance

A shopper using a mobility aid says the current checkout is too narrow. An accessible checkout is open at lane four. Ask what help they prefer, explain the available route, and ask a colleague to preserve their place; do not touch their belongings or aid without permission.

Lane four has the wider checkout space and is open now. Would you prefer directions or someone to accompany you? I'll ask my colleague to keep your place while we move the transaction. Please tell me what assistance you want; I won't assume you need help with your belongings.

Try it again: The next shopper questions why the transaction is moving. Explain briefly without disclosing personal details.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Handing over a till and an unfinished query

At shift change, the expected drawer balance is \$180 and the recorded count is \$175. A second check has not occurred, and the cause is unknown. A price query for item P32 also remains open. The incoming supervisor accepts both checks; do not accuse anyone or describe a loss as proved.

The first count is one hundred seventy-five dollars against an expected one hundred eighty, a five-dollar difference. The second check and cause are still open. Item P32 also has an unresolved price query. Please confirm you'll take both follow-ups and keep the two issues separate in the shift log.

Try it again: Someone blames the prior cashier before the check. Keep the report factual without suggesting an unrecorded cash adjustment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Retail Sales Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/sales/retail-sales-workers.htm>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Cashiers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/sales/cashiers.htm>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Retail Associate and Cashier English

Professional audience: Retail sales associates, cashiers, fitting-room attendants, and shop-floor customer service staff

Scope: All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

Lesson 01: Finding the item the shopper actually means

Original fictional case: A shopper asks for the blue shirt in an advertisement. The ad shows two blue shirts: linen L214 and cotton C218. The shopper wants a medium cotton shirt; local availability has not been checked. Confirm item and size before discussing stock.

Language workshop: Ask one question that narrows the search

Communication goal: Confirm product variation before searching for stock.

Language guidance: Color alone may describe several items. Use material, code, and size to distinguish them without claiming availability prematurely.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Do you mean the ___ or the ___? / The item code is ___; is that the one? / I'll check this store's stock in ___.

Vocabulary: stock-keeping unit: An identifier for a particular product variation, often abbreviated SKU, such as a specific shirt size and color. / barcode: A machine-readable pattern used to identify an item when scanned. / size range: The set of sizes in which a product is offered. / fitting room: A designated shop space where customers can try on clothing.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: want the medium cotton blue shirt, not the linen shirt; have not seen local stock information.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The shopper points at the wrong picture while repeating the cotton code. Clarify before searching.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The advertisement shows two blue shirts, so let me check which one you mean. Is it the cotton shirt, code C218, in medium? Once we've confirmed that variation, I can check this store's stock. The picture alone doesn't tell us whether your size is available here today.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT